

Sociology

<http://soc.sagepub.com>

The Career of the Sport Supporter: The Case of the Manchester Storm

Garry Crawford

Sociology 2003; 37; 219

DOI: 10.1177/0038038503037002001

The online version of this article can be found at:
<http://soc.sagepub.com/cgi/content/abstract/37/2/219>

Published by:



<http://www.sagepublications.com>

On behalf of:



British Sociological Association

Additional services and information for *Sociology* can be found at:

Email Alerts: <http://soc.sagepub.com/cgi/alerts>

Subscriptions: <http://soc.sagepub.com/subscriptions>

Reprints: <http://www.sagepub.com/journalsReprints.nav>

Permissions: <http://www.sagepub.co.uk/journalsPermissions.nav>

Citations <http://soc.sagepub.com/cgi/content/refs/37/2/219>



The Career of the Sport Supporter: The Case of the Manchester Storm

■ **Garry Crawford**

Sheffield Hallam University

ABSTRACT

This article presents a theorization of the induction and patterns of behaviour of the sport supporter along a social and moral career path. I argue that too often theorizations of contemporary sport supporters have relied upon restrictive and rigid typologies or dichotomies based upon excessively subjective codes of authenticity. I suggest that what is required is a return to the Chicagoan concept of status passage and career, married with an understanding of the fluidity and temporality of many contemporary 'communities'. Specifically, here I apply this model to the case of supporters of the British ice hockey team the Manchester Storm, but suggest that this theorization could be applied to many other supporter, enthusiast or fan 'communities'.

KEY WORDS

career / fans / ice hockey / sport supporters

This article presents a theorization of the career and process of induction of sport supporters,¹ with specific focus upon followers of the British ice hockey team, the Manchester Storm. The article argues that too often theorizations of contemporary sport supporters have been based upon caricatured sub-cultural models and restrictive typologies, rather than considering the process, development and often fluidity of being a contemporary sport supporter. To this end, this article argues that what is required is a return to the classic Chicagoan theorizations of career and status passage as set out by Becker, Glaser and Strauss, Goffman, Hughes, and their contemporaries.

This article begins with a discussion of Abercrombie and Longhurst's (1998) categorization of audience research, and considers and critiques the

dominant trends within the literature on British football supporters – which has, to date, dominated academic debates on sport supporters in Britain. The article then introduces a model of induction and career progression of the sport supporter, and applies this specifically to the case of the ‘live’ audience at Manchester Storm. This theorization considers the location and patterns of behaviour of sport supporters as transitional, fluid and often temporal, as these patterns develop and change along a career trajectory.

British ice hockey provides a significant case, as it is a sport that witnessed a rapid rise in popularity in Britain in the 1990s, and a reorientation and marketing towards a new family-based market. None more so than Manchester Storm, who at the time of conducting this research in the late 1990s were at their height, regularly attracting crowds in excess of 10,000 and in 1997 setting what was then a European ice hockey attendance record of 17,425 (Crawford, 2002). However, since the sport’s height in 1997, attendance levels at top-flight British ice hockey have fallen year on year, and at the time of writing this article Manchester Storm were in severe financial difficulties and struggling for survival. Moreover, the ‘authenticity’ of this (largely) new family-based consumer audience has been questioned from within the ‘traditional’ ice hockey supporter base itself (Sluyter, 1998). However, I argue that rather than being an inauthentic mass of cultural ‘dopes’ (Garfinkel, 1967), British ice hockey supporters can be seen to undergo a process of induction, follow a career progression and engage with this sport, at levels as detailed as that seen in many other sports or enthusiasms. Though membership in this supporter ‘community’ may have been relatively short-lived for some, this case illustrates the process of induction followed and the varying levels of involvement of members of this supporter base, which others may have rejected as largely ‘inauthentic’. Moreover, the theorization of a career permits a view of supporters as active social agents within the organization(s) to which they belong, and this article relates more generally to the changing nature of contemporary sport audiences.

Considering the Sport Supporter

Abercrombie and Longhurst (1998) suggest that audience research (including the study of sport fans) can be categorized into three main paradigms. First, they discuss the *Behavioural Paradigm*. This paradigm covers much of the psychological theories of audiences and some of the early thinking of sociology in this area. In this, the text or event is seen as a stimulus from which audiences passively absorb messages – with the audience often portrayed as passive or dysfunctional dopes.

The contradictions and limitations of this paradigm, Abercrombie and Longhurst suggest, have led this to be succeeded by an *Incorporation/Resistance Paradigm*. In this paradigm the audience becomes more active in its consumption, where the messages conveyed by the mass media are reinterpreted

or even rejected by audience members. Put simply, Abercrombie and Longhurst (1998: 15) suggest that the focus of this paradigm is 'whether audience are incorporated into dominant ideology by their participation in media activity, or whether to the contrary, they are resistant to that incorporation'.

Finally, Abercrombie and Longhurst argue that contradictions within this paradigm, as well as changes in the nature of audiences and developments in theory, are making it increasingly fragile, and a shift towards a new paradigm appears to be occurring – what the authors refer to as the *Spectacle/Performance Paradigm*. This paradigm is characterized by four major developments in the nature of contemporary audiences. First, people spend a lot of time in the consumption of media, both privately and publicly. Second, the mass media and everyday life have become so closely interwoven that they are increasingly inseparable. Third, we are increasingly living in a narcissistic 'performative society' where everyday mundane events become increasingly performative. Fourth, so ingrained are performances in everyday life that they become almost invisible and the distance between performer and audience becomes almost entirely removed. As they write: 'Life is a constant performance; we are audience and performer at the same time; everybody is an audience all the time. Performance is not a discrete event' (1998: 73).

Research on sport fans is an area that has been largely marginalized within academic debate. For instance, Wann and Hamlet (1995) suggest that only 4 percent of all sport sociology and psychology research focuses on sport spectators. Furthermore, of the small amount of empirical research that has been conducted on sport audiences in Britain, the vast majority has focused on football supporters (Malcolm et al., 2000). Moreover, it is primarily within Abercrombie and Longhurst's second paradigm (the Incorporation/Resistance Paradigm) that the majority of this research has been located.

As early as 1971, Ian Taylor wrote of football hooliganism as a working-class male response (read: *resistance*) to the 'bourgeoisification' of football and the increased involvement of corporate business in the running of professional football in Britain. In more recent years, the literature on British football supporters has focused most specifically around debates of the incorporation and/or resistance of supporters to contemporary patterns of commercialization within the sport.

It has been suggested that the commercial interests of the new corporate powers in professional football have led to a targeting of a new audience (a *new fandom*) of middle-class consumers at the expense of the game's 'traditional' working-class supporters (Taylor, 1995). For many authors, this commercialization is seen as a perversion of the *people's game* – leading towards a less dedicated, more fickle supporter base.

Likewise, a considerable amount of literature has been produced in recent years that considers supporter *resistance* to these patterns of commercialization within professional football in Britain – an area that has often been referred to by its authors as *fan democratization* (Brown, 1998). Considerable literature (including Jary et al., 1991, Haynes, 1993, and Brown, 1998, to name but a

few) has developed that considers fanzines, and the rise of independent supporters groups, as sites of resistance to contemporary commercial developments in professional football.

In particular, in 1993 Steve Redhead called for a consideration of the 'conflicting figures of "participatory" and "passive"' forms of football fandom' (1993: 5). Here, Redhead was referring to the rise in football fanzines and supporter organizations since the mid-1980s (the *participatory*) and the rise in support mediated through consumer products and television (the *passive*). Though Redhead suggests that this was not a simple, passive versus participatory dichotomy of football supporters, he suggests that there was 'undoubtedly a rationalising, modernising trajectory in motion which tends to create a more "respectable", more affluent audience ... leaving outside the pearly gates a large section of the game's traditional following' (1993: 6).

Such research, as with much of the hooligan literature it succeeded, is often limited in its scope, both theoretically and empirically (King, 1998). In particular, this literature often seeks to draw typologies of *types* of individuals and patterns of behaviour within distinct 'communities', often constructing typologies and dichotomies – most noticeably around issues of 'authenticity', and between incorporative 'new consumer' supporters and a resistive core of 'real fans'.

As with the literature on sub-cultures (see Bennett, 1999), typologies of supporters tend to impose rigid distinctions between 'types' of supporters, which tend towards caricature and force diverse patterns of behaviour into restrictive categories. This is also evident in many other theorizations of sport supporters (beyond British football) such as Wann et al. (2001), who construct resistive typologies between 'fans' and 'spectators', 'indirect' and 'direct' consumers, and 'highly' and 'lowly' identified fans.

Moreover, such typologies and dichotomies do not recognize the fluidity and often temporality of supporter 'communities'. As Maffesoli (1996) suggests, contemporary 'communities' are in constant flux and change, and individuals will move in and out of several of these fluid *tribus* (or neo-tribes) throughout the course of everyday life. Hence, typologies do not allow for the consideration of how the nature and composition of a supporter 'community' may change over time, and, significantly, how the composition and redefinition of patterns of support within this may be in constant flux, particularly in a media saturated society (such as contemporary Britain) where fashions and the boundaries of group membership are constantly changing and being renegotiated.

Furthermore, another *potential* difficulty with theorizations of British football supporters is that these are often developed by authors who are themselves part of the football supporter 'community'. King (1995, 1998) suggests that 'new football writers' (whom he categorizes as fan writers, such as Nick Hornby, and fanzine contributors, but I would also include many football academics) often over-romanticize the period of football in which they grew up – that of early post-war Britain. As King wrote:

New football writers imagine that their earliest experiences of football were not only the 'golden age' of football but that the terraces in those days were populated by a mythical authentic working class. (1995: 269)

The difficulty in adopting a supporter's perspective of their own supporter 'community' is that in certain cases these may become *excessively* biased. For instance, Jenkins (1996) expressed concern that many 'fan ethnographies' over-indulge personal views and perspectives, allowing research to become too obsessed with the researcher's own subjective position.

Moreover, fans clearly divide the world into 'us and them', and operate strict codes of authenticity of who and what falls into their 'fandom' (Fiske, 1992: 35). Therefore, to wholly adopt the fans' perspective as the sole source of reference is to take *their* definition of the boundaries of *their* 'community'. As Grossberg wrote:

Every fan – of whatever forms of popular culture – exists within a comparable ideology of authenticity. ... This ideological difference has taken many forms, which are not necessarily the same: centre vs. margin, rock vs. pop, the mainstream vs. the periphery, commercial vs. independent, co-opted vs. resistant. (1992: 62)

Williams (2000: 102) suggests that this has been particularly evident in much of the literature on the commercialization of British football, which tends to overly-romanticize images of football's 'golden age' – constructing a series of binary oppositions such as 'fans' against "consumers", "live" attenders against TV fans, and "traditional" supporters (good) against "new" fans (obviously bad)'. Therefore, I would agree with the assertion made by Grossberg (1992: 52):

While we may all agree that there is a difference between the fan and the consumer, we are unlikely to understand the difference if we simply celebrate the former category and dismiss the latter one.

Moreover, the Incorporation/Resistance Paradigm has been extensively criticized by Abercrombie and Longhurst (1998). In particular, Abercrombie and Longhurst identify three key weaknesses with this paradigm. First, they argue that the creative and resistive powers of an audience are often overstated within this paradigm, and that 'activism does not of itself give power or even the capacity to resist' (1998: 30). Second, that this research revolves around grand theories of power relations, but often lacks adequate empirical foundation. Moreover, that what empirical research does exist shows an increasing fragmentation rather than coherence of audience and consumer patterns. Finally, that this paradigm employs a unitary and hierarchical notion of social power relations. This, Abercrombie and Longhurst argue, can be contested from two perspectives. First, drawing on the work of Foucault (1979), they argue that power relations are in constant flux and can therefore never be resolved. Second, that this paradigm revolves primarily around power relations based upon class relations. However, power relations are increasingly complex, involving also gender, age and ethnicity (to name but a few), and hence it proves

increasingly difficult to talk of a central power axis around which this Incorporation/Resistance Paradigm revolves.

However, many attempts to move the literature on football supporters away from this reductionist paradigm have continued to suffer from the same subjective distinction between traditional (read: *authentic*) and new (read: *inauthentic*) supporters. For instance, Redhead's (1997) consideration of a football 'post-fandom'² is clearly an attempt to move beyond the dichotomy of 'passive' and 'participatory' supporters he sets up in 1993, and to suggest these boundaries have begun to break down. However, it is apparent from a careful reading of this text that Redhead views this breakdown as a recent phenomenon, and that there still remains a participatory (though reduced), 'authentic', core of football supporters. As his discussion of the 1994 World Cup shows:

A more 'passive', as opposed to 'participatory', audience for soccer is one possible outcome as sport is globally consumed more and more through the mediation of television. American 'live' audiences at USA '94 were predicted to be the least committed and knowledgeable of any World Cup held so far. ... [However] it was clear that sections of many crowds contained passionate and 'authentic' fans from competing nations as at any other World Cup finals. (1997: 44)

Redhead's (like Baudrillard's) obsession with the post-modern and hyper-real blindly and romantically presumes there once existed a 'real' and 'authentic' culture and juxtaposes this with the post-modern. For instance, Kellner (1989: 75) suggests that Baudrillard romanticizes 'direct unmediated and reciprocal speech which is denied in a media society ... forgetting that all language is mediated (through language and signs and so on)'.

The majority of theorization of contemporary football supporters remains firmly within the Incorporation/Resistance Paradigm so heavily criticized by Abercrombie and Longhurst (1998). And as with much of the literature in this paradigm, this fails to fully acknowledge the fluidity and (often) temporary nature of contemporary supporter 'communities', and the highly subjective nature of many fan typologies, dichotomies and codes of 'authenticity'.

Hence, I suggest that it is far more useful to recognize the historical and cultural specificity of 'authenticity' and supporter 'communities', and adopt a more fluid model of patterns of support as a process and career. Consequently, it is to the literature on status passage and career that I now wish to turn.

Theorizing Status Passage and Career

The concept of 'status passage', Glaser and Strauss (1971) suggest, originates in the anthropology of Arnold van Gennep (1908), where it is used to signify the passage of an individual through various stages in a life course (such as shifting from being unmarried to married). However, this concept has been expanded greatly within sociology to incorporate the study of occupational and organizational mobility, and the process of socialization and career progression. In

particular, this is a field of sociology that has been developed most notably by successive generations of academics tied to the University of Chicago (Glaser, 1968a).

Status passage, and specifically the consideration of a social career, Goffman (1968) suggests, are concepts that have been most closely linked to studies of individual (and collective) development within a formal organization, and, most frequently, within a rigid occupational structure. However, Goffman continues, careers need not necessarily be viewed as solely occupational, but can also constitute any form of (often mundane and everyday) social progression. For example, Glaser (1968b) offers a consideration of the status progression of medical interns, while Becker (1963) famously charts the careers of marijuana users and dance musicians, while Goffman (1968) presents a consideration of the (moral) career of 'mental patients'.

For Goffman (1968: 119), the career of the 'mental patient' is a moral one as it involves a development of an individual's identity and 'entails [changes] in the person's self and his [sic] framework of imagery for judging himself [sic] and others'. Goffman (1968: 119) finds the concept of career most useful in considering the changes in identity of 'mental patients', as it allows for a two-sided view of this process, where 'one side is linked to internal matters ... such as self and felt identity; the other side concerns official position, jural relations, and style of life'. Hence, the concept of a career is based upon what Galtung (1966) refers to as both ascribed and achieved status or, as Goffman argues (1968: 119), it '... allows one to move back and forth between the personal and the public, between the self and its significant society ...'.

Crucially, then, the concept of a career ties in both elements of structure and agency, ascribed and achieved status, and individual and institutional definitions of rank. Moreover, although as Hughes (1968: 17) suggests career paths and structures can be quite rigid and persistent in their structure and form, in some organizations and 'communities' these may be (what Hughes refers to as) 'disordered', and I would extend this to include fluid and temporal.

Though the concept of a career is often linked with theorizations of sub-cultures, Donnelly (2000) argues that it is possible to discuss sub-cultures without resorting to the concept of career. Likewise, I argue that the concept of a career can be applied to a far more fluid and flexible theorization of group membership than that offered by a sub-culturalist framework.

Therefore, adopting the theorization of a career and process of induction when considering the development and patterns of behaviour of contemporary sport supporters has several advantages over using sub-cultural categories, typologies or (non-career based) continua. First, the use of the term career moves away from restrictive typologies and dichotomies that caricature patterns of behaviour and force individuals into often ill-defined and rigid 'types' of supporters, and allows for a more fluid and dynamic understanding of the structure of a 'community' and the nature of an individual's (or collective's) progression. For instance, Glaser and Strauss (1971: 4–5) suggest status passages can often be reversed and repeated; individuals may progress alone or

together; progression may be voluntary or enforced; it may involve special legitimation to progress; and signs of passages may vary greatly in their levels of clarity, and may not always be visible to all. Second, it allows for an understanding of how an individual's position within the career and involvement with the sport (or sports) can change and develop over a life course. Third, it also permits a consideration of how the supporter 'community' (and the nature and career 'structure' of this 'community') can change and develop over time – as with studies of ecology, as an individual develops over time (an ontogenetical development) there will also be in process a general development of the species to which that individual belongs (a phylogenetical development). Fourth, it is also important to recognize that individuals will belong to numerous 'communities' and groups, which (following Maffesoli, 1996) they will move in and out of several times in their everyday lives, and hence will follow several (often cross-cutting) career paths. Finally, whereas sub-cultures, typologies and non-career-based continua tend towards characterizing individuals (and allocating a 'type') on the basis of set patterns of behaviour and traits, the concept of a career permits an understanding of how two individuals occupying a similar career position may have differing (but equitable) characteristics and patterns of behaviour (in a similar vein to how two individuals suffering from a similar mental illness, such as schizophrenia, may elicit completely different symptoms).

Hence, while *typical* patterns of behaviour can be identified within a supporter career, the temporality and fluidity of these must always be acknowledged. Similarly, as Bourdieu and Wacquant (1992: 133) suggest in relation to the concept of habitus:

Habitus is not the fate that some people read into it. Being the product of history, it is an open system of dispositions that is constantly subjected to experiences, and therefore constantly affected by them in a way that either reinforces or modifies its structure.

Hence, it is the adoption of a loosely defined career structure and process of induction, coupled with an understanding of the fluidity and temporarily of many groups and 'communities' in contemporary society, which I suggest offers the most profitable theorization of the contemporary sport supporter. And specifically, I apply this theorization to the case of the supporter base at Manchester Storm.

The Careers of Manchester Storm Supporters

The majority of typologies and categorizations applied to sport supporters, and in particular those constructed around British football supporters, have little applicability to the supporter base at Manchester Storm. For instance, Redhead's (1993) dichotomy between 'passive' and 'participatory' forms of football support cannot be directly applied to the case of Manchester Storm.

Unlike football, ice hockey in Britain is still primarily based around attending a 'live' sporting event, hence Redhead's distinction between those who attend 'live' games, and those whose support is mediated through consumer and media goods has little application here. Furthermore, I question any theory that primarily seeks to divide supporters by excessively subjective and biased codes of 'authenticity'.

Rather, here I present a theorization of the process of induction and progression of a Manchester Storm supporter along a (moral) career path. I use the term 'moral' as, following Goffman (1968), the development of a supporter at Manchester Storm involves changes in the individual's own identity as a supporter, and significantly how they categorize and judge their own and others' behaviour.

Drawing on 41 interviews and over 1400 survey respondents from Manchester Storm supporters, and three years of participant observation in Britain and the US, Figure 1 sets out a model of the *typical* career progression of a supporter at Manchester Storm.

This model (with some adaptation) could be applied to numerous other sports or enthusiasms. The 'live' audience at Manchester Storm (as with other British ice hockey audiences) is quite distinct when compared to many other mass spectator sport audiences. The audience at Manchester Storm is primarily a local, family based, affluent (working-class) audience, which engages in high levels of sport related consumption both at and away from the 'live' venue (Crawford, 2001). However, the general theorization of a career path and process of induction could be applied to numerous other supporter 'communities'. For instance, Marsh (1978) has applied the concept of a career to the consideration of football hooligans, while Jones (2000) suggests that the majority of football supporters likewise undergo a process of induction and career progression.

Furthermore, though this theorization of career progression is based upon empirical research on supporters who have attended at least one 'live' sports event, it is my assertion that this conceptualization could be applied to supporters who connect primarily (if not solely) with sport through mass media and consumer sources.

In a mass media saturated society (such as contemporary Britain) flooded with sport related consumer goods, an individual's primary connection with a sport is often via mass media or consumer items. However, this does not necessarily mean that an individual's sense of belonging to a supporter 'community' is any less developed, nor does it preclude the possibility of undergoing a similar process of induction and career development to those who regularly attend a 'live' sports event.

This career path draws on, and combines, elements of both Moorhouse's (1991) model and Abercrombie and Longhurst's (1998) continuum of enthusiasms. However, unlike Moorhouse and Abercrombie and Longhurst, the labels used here are not categories, but rather points along a career trajectory. Though progression along this path may be linear, it is often far more complex and individuals may regress, leapfrog certain positions or move in and out of this career

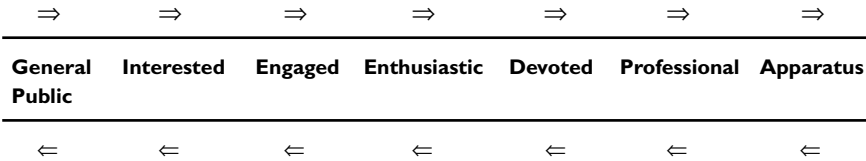


Figure 1 Career progression of the Manchester Storm supporter

structure at any time. For instance, I myself spent my first season of attending Manchester Storm games at the supporter base periphery (as a member of the ‘interested’ public), but upon admittance to the press box at the Manchester Arena (in my second season of attending), quickly progressed to the level of ‘professional’.

Likewise, the majority of interviewees were able to describe how their pattern of support had developed over the period that they had been attending ice hockey games, and often comments highlighted stages of progression along a recognisable career path – such as the comments made by Diane (female, aged about 35, enthusiastic/devoted):³

... yes it’s funny, because in the first season I would have joined in with all the dancing bits that were going on for a laugh, but I don’t now ... that’s because I’m so busy watching the game ... I find [dancing] slightly distracting ...

Furthermore, it appears that social interaction plays a crucial role in introducing individuals to ice hockey and facilitates their career progression. Both Becker (1963) and Bourdieu (1984) point to the importance of tuition in learning the norms of a social group. For Bourdieu, social interaction allows individuals to learn the norms of a particular habitus and become initiated in this. Becker (1963) similarly discusses how marijuana users, through social interaction and tuition, learn how to behave and participate in this culture. Similarly, the majority of interviewees in the Manchester Storm research were able to name numerous individuals they had introduced to ice hockey. For instance, when Keith (male, aged 24, enthusiastic) was asked if he had ever introduced anyone to ice hockey, he responded:

... a few, like a friend of mine I took and now she’s a regular season ticket buyer. ... Then there’s the ice hockey nut [a friend of his], the guy with the data-base and everything, that was just taking him to one game ... he’d sort of been watching it on TV, but now he’s ... completely hooked. That’s where he met his current girlfriend, at the ice hockey, and I get a feeling they are going to get married at the Arena, and name all the babies after the players [only half joking].

Likewise, when interviewees were asked how they had learnt the rules and tactics of the game, the vast majority pointed towards the tuition of others. As Gerry (male, aged 18, enthusiastic) responded when asked how he had learnt the rules of the sport:

... not from watching the game, because the referees are awful. Storm try and help supporters with the rules. Like at the start of the game they put the rules on the screen and in the match programme ... but I know all, well virtually all, the rules, and if there are any I don't know I ask my friend 'cause he knows all the rules ...

This tuition is not restricted to 'direct' interaction (such as conversations), nor is it limited to the understanding of the sport. In particular, at Manchester Storm patterns of consumption, spectacle and surveillance play significant roles in tutoring and shaping individuals' behaviour. Surveillance and 'the gaze' from the stewards, cameras and other supporters 'encourage' supporters to regulate and 'normalize' their own behaviour (Foucault, 1979). Furthermore, it is through observing the spectacles and consumer patterns around the Arena, and by learning and replicating these, that supporters learn (and adopt) the norms of the ice hockey and Manchester Storm habitus – allowing progression along the career path. Moreover, as already suggested, patterns of ice hockey support in Britain often involve high levels of consumption and mass media use (Crawford, 2001). Hence, this process of tuition and induction is also likely to be fuelled through information and resources obtained through the mass media and consumer goods, and hence much of this process of induction and progression may take place outside of the walls of the 'live' arena.

However, certain of the more 'dedicated' supporters (i.e. devoted and professional) are more likely to attribute their understanding of the sport and position at the very centre of the supporter base to their 'experience' and 'expert' knowledge, rather than as the result of a process of tuition and development. Take for example the comments made by Robert (male, aged 27, devoted) when asked how he had learned the rules of the sport:

Just through watching the game ... it's like most sports isn't it? The rules [are] open to interpretation as seen by the referee, and I think getting used to the referees and how they see it ... but once you know who the referee is you have a pretty good idea if the game is going to flow or whether it's going to be littered with penalties ...

In many respects, the attitudes of 'devoted' and 'professional' supporters reflect those of elitist opinions towards art and high culture as considered by Bourdieu (1984) – where individuals are more willing to attribute their 'expertise' to an (almost) natural ability, rather than as a result of tuition and learning. In this way, devoted and professional supporters at Manchester Storm seek to assert their legitimacy and position (and distinguish themselves from other supporters) on the basis of either their 'natural' understanding of the game, or superior knowledge and experience.

Before progressing further, it is important to note that induction and career progression into a supporter 'community' may not appeal or even be open to all. For instance, Crawford (2002) suggests that arena based sports such as British ice hockey in their warm, safe, 'family-friendly' environment have many aspects that appeal to more middle-class sensibilities (or pretensions). Furthermore, British ice hockey has a supporter 'community' that often involves high levels of consumption and mass media use. Hence, ice hockey may

lack appeal outside its 'core market', or exclude those who cannot participate in this consumer culture.

Similarly, though almost half of the audience regularly seen at British ice hockey games are women (Crawford, 2001), female supporters are often 'excluded' from progressing into the highest echelons of this supporter 'community'. Women's under-representation in many other supporter 'communities', and in particular professional football in Britain (Woodhouse and Williams, 1999), often sees their support deemed somehow 'inauthentic' by other (often male) supporters. Hence, certain individuals may see their progression (or even induction) into a supporter 'community' limited or even prohibited altogether.

Some *typical* characteristics and attitudes expressed by the seven career points set out in this theorization are discussed below. Once more, it is important to remember that these are only *illustrative* examples of behaviour and attitudes of supporters *attending* Manchester Storm games, and not a regimented typology of behaviour.

General Public and Interested

The career path begins with the general public, who will have varying levels of interest or knowledge in the given subject matter (in this case British ice hockey). Career progression will start to move towards the 'interested' position when the individual begins to take more of a specific interest in the subject.

Little is known about these early career positions. For instance, many interviewees at Manchester Storm suggested that they were interested in ice hockey before they attended their first game, and had watched it on television or in a film, played an ice hockey computer game, looked for the results in the mass media, or similar. As Eric (male, aged 44, enthusiastic) stated:

Yeah ... I was interested myself [before first attending a 'live' game] ... I've always enjoyed it, I've always watched the Stanley Cup on television, on Grandstand and that, donkey's years ago.

The assumption is, then, that there exists an unknown number of individuals who may not consider themselves followers of this sport, but will show some passing interest in it. However, it is likely that for British ice hockey the 'interested' position will be far less populated than with many sports such as football, rugby and cricket in Britain (or ice hockey in North America) that receive far greater media coverage.

Engaged

Individuals progress towards this position when they begin to 'engage' with the sport (or enthusiasm) at a more specific level. At Manchester Storm this position consists of infrequent attendees and newcomers and a large number of

transitory members. Though there will be some stable members, many individuals in this position will either drift away or slip back and forth from the 'interested' position, while others will become more interested/dedicated and progress further along the career trajectory.

Typical characteristics of 'engaged' supporters at Manchester Storm are that they are unlikely to own merchandise, tend not to be season ticket holders and are unlikely to be members of the supporters club, or feel part of an ice hockey 'community'. They are more likely to value entertainment at the arena over the success of the team, tend to have little understanding of the history or rules of game, and do not usually operate codes of authenticity – but may acknowledge that they are not 'fans' themselves. Take, for example, the comments made by Jill (female, aged about 50, engaged/enthusiastic) when asked if she considered herself a 'fan' of ice hockey:

No ... It's more the kids that enjoy it, and like I say, I enjoy it when I'm there and I support them ... but I wouldn't say 'oh no, I couldn't live without them'.

Enthusiastic

This group consists probably of three to five thousand supporters at Manchester Storm who fairly regularly attend home games. Hence, at low attendance games (such as mid-week cup matches) 'enthusiastic' supporters will be by far the largest section present.

Typical characteristics and attitudes of the 'enthusiastic' position at Manchester Storm would include success becoming more important (but not crucial). This development is characterized by Paul (male, aged 40, enthusiastic) when asked if success at Manchester Storm was as important to him when he first started attending as it is to him now:

[Winning was] nothing at all ... it was [just] a game of ice hockey, a bit of fun ... But... this last season ... it was like, ruining my weekend if it didn't happen ... of course it's not win at all costs, you want to be entertained and have a good match, but the result's important, very important.

At Manchester Storm 'enthusiastic' supporters will probably be members of the supporters club. They are more likely to own merchandise and display this at (and away from) the Arena. They are also likely to operate varying codes of authenticity/differentiation but these tend not to be very strong (such as suggesting there exists a 'fanatical' core of fans – a group to which they do not belong).

Devoted

'Devoted' supporters are a smaller section of (primarily) long-term followers. Typical characteristics and attitudes of 'devoted' supporters at Manchester

Storm may include having been following ice hockey since Manchester Storm's first season, or even before this. Individuals at this career position will probably own and display (often considerable amounts) of ice hockey related merchandise. 'Devoted' supporters are likely to operate fairly strict codes of authenticity, and express dislike for some other supporters or behaviour (such as children, dancing, Mexican waves and the like). 'Devoted' supporters will generally have a good understanding of the rules of ice hockey, knowledge of the game outside of the British Super League (most commonly of the NHL) and may have some understanding of the history of the sport. 'Devoted' supporters at Manchester Storm (and I would suggest at many other sports) are most likely to be male. Robert (male, aged 27, devoted) expresses many of the typical characteristics of a 'devoted' supporter:

Everyone else seems to class me as an anorak ... [but] I'm not a trivia buff 'cause I couldn't go on all about the NHL's history and stuff like that, but over the past two or three years pretty much any player who has passed through a British team if you mention a name I could tell you what position, what number, which team, which team he played for prior to that and maybe which team he played for prior to that. So yeah, I am aiming for anorak status [laughs].

Professional

This section is a very small 'elite' group (of less than a dozen members at Manchester Storm), and consists of those who make at least a partial amount of their income from their involvement in ice hockey. At Manchester Storm this group is exclusively white, over the age of 30, and almost wholly male – though some women occupy positions on the fringes of this group. Generally, 'professional' supporters at Manchester Storm are either well educated and/or have non-manual and fairly affluent occupations away from ice hockey. In many respects this is similar to the social profiles of British football fanzine editors and contributors Taylor (1995), King (1995, 1998) and Giulianotti (1997) identify as being largely consisting of a small, middle-class, highly educated minority of football supporters.

Typical characteristics of 'professional' supporters at Manchester Storm are that they will tend to be season ticket holders (if they do not receive complimentary tickets), but are unlikely to be members of the supporters club – as they are part of their own select group. They are unlikely to have rivalries with other teams, as they see themselves as part of a wider hockey 'family'. They are likely to own (often considerable amounts of) merchandise (both Manchester Storm and North American) but will not usually display or wear this (save a discrete pin-badge, baseball cap or the like). As highlighted in the comments made by Alex (male, aged about 45, professional) whose patterns of support have changed and developed with his career progression:

When I was a fan, if you like, when I was a fan at Altrincham with Trafford, yes I wore a game shirt every game, I wore the colours. I did wear the colours, every

game, home and away I would have my shirt on and my daughter would have her shirt on ... but if you like, since becoming involved with the Storm on a more serious perspective, no I wouldn't wear a game shirt. I just wouldn't. I don't know why, it's like a pigeonhole. I was a fan, now I'm a fan who's got a serious involvement with the club so I have to divorce ... You don't see John Motson [a football commentator] in his Liverpool kit do you? So that's the thing ... when working for ...[broadcasting company's name]... one doesn't look a twat.

'Professional' supporters also tend to have been following British ice hockey for many years, well before the creation of the Storm, and will often have quite detailed knowledge of the sport's rules and tactics, a good understanding of the sport in North America and Europe, and knowledge of the sport's history.

Apparatus

The apparatus consists of the individuals involved in the running and administration of the sport or enthusiasm, such as marketing directors, company chairpersons, team managers and the like, who are most frequently employed full time within this. This position is rarely included in characterizations of supporters or enthusiasts (Moorhouse [1991] being a notable exception) as members of this group most frequently enter into this position directly due to their expertise or experience. However, there are a number of examples of individuals whose enthusiasm has led on to careers within the industry. For instance, the Match Night Co-ordinator at Manchester Storm (male, aged about 50, apparatus) and the Press Secretary at Belfast Giants (male, aged about 50, apparatus) are just two examples of several individuals who have followed the career path of a supporter into the heart of the apparatus.

Conclusion

The area of sport support is one that still remains both largely under-researched and under-theorized. The literature that does exist on supporters, and particularly that which focuses on British football supporters, has been largely based upon restrictive dichotomies or typologies that caricature supporters' traits and fail to recognize the fluidity and temporality of contemporary social networks.

In this article I have suggested that a way forward is to present a consideration of the behaviour and traits of supporters along a career trajectory that draws upon a Chicagoan theorization of a (moral) career – a theorization that complements, and marries with, more contemporary discussions of the fluidity and temporality of (late-)modern 'communities', and in particular that of Maffesoli (1996).

This theorization has a number of advantages over typologies or non-career based continua set out in many existing conceptualizations of sport supporters. It allows for an understanding of a supporter's position within a

supporter 'community' as the product of both 'achieved' and 'ascribed' status – and hence as a product of both 'agency' and 'structure'. It recognizes the fluidity and temporality of many supporter 'communities', how an individual's position in this can change over time, and how they can belong to numerous 'communities' and groups, which they move in and out of several times each day. Moreover, this theorization recognizes that the attributes and progression of a supporter within any supporter 'community' are unlikely to be uniform, and individuals occupying a similar career position may demonstrate different (though equitable) characteristics in their patterns of support and attitudes. Hence, dichotomies such as those between 'passive' and 'participatory' or 'direct' and 'indirect' supporters dissolve in this theorization – acknowledging that in contemporary society there are numerous ways individuals can connect with mass spectator sports, both at and away from the 'live' venue, and that all of these are mediated to a greater or lesser degree.

However, this theorization recognizes that career progression within (or even induction into) a supporter community may not be open to all. In particular, female followers of certain (most often male sports) are often deemed as 'inauthentic' ('not real fans') and hence their career progression may be limited. Furthermore, as sport support becomes increasingly mediated through mass media resources and consumer goods (particularly in relation to British ice hockey), economic capital becomes a greater barrier than ever before, restricting the opportunities many have to (literally) 'buy into' certain supporter 'communities'.

Finally, this article has presented an application of this theorization to the supporter base at Manchester Storm. This case is of particular significance as it is a 'live' audience that has been characterized as inauthentic and part of an incorporative consumer mass by many, but here I have highlighted the (relative) complexity and diversity of this group's patterns of behaviour. Furthermore, what an analysis of this case demonstrates is the importance of social interaction and tuition in the induction and career progression of a sport supporter, both via face-to-face interaction, and through less direct means such as the use of the mass media and consumer goods, observing and mimicking the behaviour of other supporters, and the normalizing gaze of the arena.

Acknowledgements

I would like to thank Professor Brian Longhurst and Dr Greg Smith (both at the University of Salford) and Ms Victoria Gosling (University of Sheffield) for their comments on earlier drafts of this article.

Notes

- 1 I prefer the use of the term 'supporter' to that of 'fan', as fan is often associated with distinctions of authenticity (such as being a 'real' fan), which I seek to

move beyond. However, the term fan appears the dominant label within this debate, and hence in certain contexts (such as where citing others) use of this term is unavoidable.

- 2 This term Redhead (allegedly) borrows from Giulianotti (1999: 148).
- 3 All interviewees have been allocated a position (or location between two positions) along the career structure as set out in Figure 1.

References

- Abercrombie, N. and B. Longhurst (1998) *Audiences*. London: Sage.
- Becker, H.S. (1963) *Outsiders: Studies in the Sociology of Deviance*. London: Free Press.
- Bennett, A. (1999) 'Subcultures or Neo-Tribes? Rethinking the Relationship Between Youth, Style and Musical Taste', *Sociology* 33(3): 599–617.
- Bourdieu, P. (1984) *Distinction: A Critique of the Judgement of Taste*. London: Routledge.
- Bourdieu, P. and L. Wacquant (1992) *An Invitation to Reflexive Sociology*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Brown, A. (1998) 'United We Stand: Some Problems with Fan Democracy', in A. Brown (ed.) *Fanatics! Power, Identity and Fandom in Football*. London: Routledge.
- Crawford, G. (2001) 'Characteristics of a British Ice Hockey Audience – Major Findings of the 1998 and 1999 Manchester Storm Ice Hockey Club Supporter Surveys', *International Review for the Sociology of Sport* 36(1): 71–81.
- Crawford, G. (2002) 'The Coming of the Storm: Fresh Cultural Pastures for the Cultural Tourists?', *Culture, Sport, Society* 5(1): 21–38.
- Donnelly, P. (2000) 'Interpretative Approaches to the Sociology of Sport', pp. 77–91 in J. Coakley and E. Dunning (eds) *Handbook of Sports Studies*. London: Sage.
- Fiske, J. (1992) 'The Cultural Economy of Fandom', pp. 30–49 in L. Lewis (ed.) *The Adoring Audience*. London: Routledge.
- Foucault, M. (1979) *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Harmondsworth: Penguin.
- Galtung, J. (1966) 'Rank and Social Integration: A Multidimensional Approach', pp. 145–98 in J. Berger, M. Zelditch and B. Anderson (eds) *Sociological Theories in Process*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.
- Garfinkel, H. (1967) *Studies in Ethnomethodology*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.
- Giulianotti, R. (1997) 'Enlightening the North: Aberdeen Fanzines and Local Football Identity', pp. 211–38 in G. Armstrong and R. Giulianotti (eds) *Entering the Field: New Perspectives on World Football*. London: Berg.
- Giulianotti, R. (1999) *Football: A Sociology of the Global Game*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Glaser, B.G. (1968a) 'Towards a Theory of Organizational Careers', pp. 13–16 in B.G. Glaser (ed.) *Organizational Careers*. Chicago: Aldine.
- Glaser, B.G. (1968b) 'Internship Appointments of Medical Students', pp. 405–12 in B.G. Glaser (ed.) *Organizational Careers*. Chicago: Aldine.
- Glaser, B.G. and A.L. Strauss (1971) *Status Passage*. London: Routledge.

- Goffman, E. (1968) *Asylums*. London: Penguin.
- Grossberg, L. (1992) 'Is there a Fan in the House?: The Affective Sensibility of Fandom', in L.A. Lewis (ed.) *The Adoring Audience: Fan Culture and Popular Media*. London: Routledge.
- Haynes, R. (1993) 'Vanguard or Vagabond? A History of *When Saturday Comes*', pp. 45–54 in S. Redhead (ed.) *The Passion and the Fashion: Football Fandom in the New Europe*. Aldershot: Avebury.
- Hughes, E.C. (1968) 'Career and Office', pp. 17–20 in B.G. Glaser (ed.) *Organizational Careers*. Chicago: Aldine.
- Jary, D., J. Horne and T. Bucke (1991) 'Football "Fanzines" and Football Culture: A Case of Successful "Cultural Contestation"', *Sociological Review* 39(3): 581–98.
- Jenkins, H. (1996) 'Interview', pp. 256–79 in T. Harrison, S. Projansky, K.A. Ono and E.R. Helford *Enterprise Zones: Critical Positions on Star Trek*. London: Westview Press.
- Jones, I. (2000) 'A Mode of Serious Leisure Identification: The Case of Football Fandom', *Leisure Studies* 19(4): 283–93.
- Kellner, D. (1989) *Jean Baudrillard: From Marxism to Postmodernism and Beyond*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- King, A. (1995) *The Premier League and the New Consumption of Football*. University of Salford, unpublished PhD thesis.
- King, A. (1998) *The End of the Terraces*. Leicester: Leicester University Press.
- Maffesoli, M. (1996) *The Time of the Tribes: The Decline of Individualism in Mass Society*. London: Sage.
- Malcolm, D., I. Jones and I. Waddington (2000) 'The People's Game? Football Spectatorship and Demographic Change', pp. 129–43 in J. Garland, D. Malcolm and M. Rowe (eds) *The Future of Football: Challenges for the Twenty-First Century*. London: Frank Cass.
- Marsh, P. (1978) 'Life and Careers on the Football Terraces', pp. 61–81 in R. Ingham (ed.) *Football Hooliganism*. London: Inter-Action Trust.
- Moorhouse, H.F. (1991) *Driving Ambitions: An Analysis of the American Hot Rod Enthusiasm*. Manchester: Manchester University Press.
- Redhead, S. (1993) 'Always Look on the Bright Side of Life', pp. 1–12 in S. Redhead (ed.) *The Passion and the Fashion: Football Fandom in the New Europe*. Aldershot: Avebury.
- Redhead, S. (1997) *Post-Fandom and the Millennial Blues: The Transformation of Soccer Culture*. London: Routledge.
- Sluyter, L. (1998) *A Game of Three Halves*. London: Mainstream.
- Taylor, I. (1995) 'It's a Whole New Ball Game', *Salford Papers in Sociology*. Salford: University of Salford.
- Van Gennep, A. (1908) *Les Rites de Passage* (translated by M. Vizedom and G. Cafee, Chicago, Chicago University Press, 1960).
- Wann, D.L. and M. Hamlet (1995) 'Author and Subject Gender in Sport Research', *International Journal of Sports Psychology* 26: 225–32.
- Wann, D.L., M.J. Melnick, G.W. Russell. and D.G. Pease (2001) *Sports Fans: The Psychology and Social Impact of Spectators*. New York: Routledge.
- Williams, J. (2000) 'The Changing Face of Football: A Case of National Regulation?', pp. 94–106 in S. Hamil, J. Michie, C. Oughton and S. Warby

(eds) *Football in the Digital Age: Whose Game is it Anyway?* London: Mainstream.

Woodhouse, D. and J. Williams (1999) *Offside? The Position of Women in Football*. Reading: South Street.

Garry Crawford

Is a lecturer in Social and Cultural Studies in Sport at Sheffield Hallam University. He received his PhD in Sociology from the University of Salford in 2001, and current research interests include sport supporters and forms of sport related consumption.

Address: School of Sport and Leisure Management, Collegiate Campus, Sheffield Hallam University, Sheffield, South Yorkshire S10 2BP, UK.

E-mail: crawford1972@bigfoot.com